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Gasping for Oxygen



Early in *Interstellar* Professor Brand says to Cooper: “Earth’s atmosphere is 80 percent nitrogen. We don’t even breathe nitrogen. Blight does. And as it thrives, our air gets less and less oxygen. The last people to starve will be the first to suffocate. And your daughter’s generation will be the last to survive on Earth.”

Is there any basis in science for the Professor’s prediction?

This question lies at the interface of two branches of science: biology and geophysics. So I asked the biologists at our Blight Dinner, particularly Elliot Meyerowitz, and I asked two geophysicists, Caltech professors Gerald Wasserburg (an expert on the origin and history of the Earth, Moon, and solar system) and Yuk Yung (an expert on the physics and chemistry of our Earth’s atmosphere, and the atmospheres of other planets). From them, and from technical articles they pointed me to, I learned the following.